Unravelling this configuration is possible on account of details available from subsequent historical records. The dam built in Chandragupta's time is mentioned as having been embellished in the time of Ashoka. The signature of these monarchs on the dam is not known from Mauryan records but was recorded in the Junagadh rock inscription of the king Rudradaman, more than 350 years after Chandragupta.[3] This tells us that Mauryan monarchs were part of the historically remembered landscape of Junagadh in the early centuries CE. Still, that this glimpse is offered some four centuries after the dam was built highlights the non-contemporary nature of the evidentiary threads used for re-creating the fabric of Junagadh's landscape in the time of Ashoka.

Considering the time lag, can this inscriptional reference be used for understanding state-building in Mauryan times?

The existence of the Rudradaman record makes it possible to speak of at least a quasi all-India state authority with a ground-level administrative presence in Junagadh. The epigraph tells us the dam was constructed by Vaisya Pushyagupta, a provincial governor of Chandragupta.[4] The same record notes that conduits had been added to it by the Yavana king Tushaspha, who governed the province in the reign of Ashoka. Evidently, one of the emperor's governors shared ethnic affiliations with the Yavana rulers on the north-western borders of the kingdom. Perhaps more noteworthy is that this system of governance, in the longer-term political history of Saurashtra, is an aberration, for only when an all-India state possessed enormous strength could it bring Saurashtra into its administrative orbit.[5] So, for instance, though the Marathas collected tribute from this province, they were not powerful enough to establish an administrative apparatus within it. Only when Akbar conquered Saurashtra in the sixteenth century was Gujarat governed by officers appointed by the Mughal. Akbar was in this respect the first ruler after Chandragupta to have properly conquered Saurashtra—in the sense of also establishing his own